



Information Technology
Operations Specialist

WEBD 1000 — Website Development

Workshop 1 — Website Evaluation

Course: WEBD 1000 — Website Development

Instructor: Davis Boudreau

Activity: Workshop 1

Type: Graded Workshop — 3%

Topic: Topic 2 — Usability & Accessibility

Relevant Learning Outcome: Outcome 1 — *Evaluate a variety of web sites for usability and accessibility.*

Activity Overview

In Workshop 0, you established the technical environment you'll use throughout WEBD 1000.

You can now:

Develop → View → Inspect → Commit → Push → Publish

The next question is not:

Can we build a website?

Instead, we begin with:

What makes a website effective for the people who use it?

Before designing your own Semester Website Project, you need to learn how to examine existing websites critically.

In this workshop, you'll evaluate real websites using principles of:

- usability;
- accessibility;
- visual hierarchy;
- contrast;

- repetition;
- alignment;
- proximity;
- navigation;
- readability;
- consistency.

You'll move beyond statements such as:

"I like this website."

or:

"This website looks bad."

Those are personal reactions.

A useful website evaluation requires you to identify a specific design decision, explain how it affects the user, and support your evaluation with evidence.

The evaluation process introduced in this workshop will also help you make better decisions when planning your own Semester Website Project.

Learning Objectives

By completing this workshop, you will be able to:

1. Explain the difference between usability, accessibility, and visual design.
2. Apply the design principles of contrast, repetition, alignment, and proximity when evaluating a webpage.
3. Identify interface features that help or interfere with usability.
4. Identify common accessibility considerations in web content.
5. Evaluate website navigation and information clarity.
6. Use browser Developer Tools to support website inspection.
7. Separate personal preference from evidence-based evaluation.
8. Document observations using screenshots and written evidence.
9. Recommend practical improvements based on identified problems.
10. Apply lessons from existing websites to your future Semester Website Project.

Concept Review / Lesson Content

1. A Website Is Built for a User

Websites aren't simply collections of HTML, CSS, images, and links.

They exist to help people accomplish something.

A user might visit a website to:

- find information;
- purchase a product;
- register for a service;
- contact an organization;
- complete a form;
- read an article;
- watch content;
- locate a business;
- perform a task.

This means an important question when evaluating a website is:

Can the intended user accomplish what they came here to do?

A visually impressive website can still be difficult to use.

A technically functioning website can still be inaccessible.

A simple website can be extremely effective.

2. Purpose and Audience

Before judging a website, determine what the website is trying to accomplish.

Ask:

- What is this website for?
- Who appears to be its intended audience?
- What are users likely trying to accomplish?
- What information or actions appear most important?

For example, imagine a restaurant website.

A visitor might want to:

- view the menu;
- check opening hours;
- find the location;
- make a reservation;
- contact the restaurant.

If those common tasks are difficult to complete, the website may have a usability problem even if it looks attractive.

3. Usability

Usability describes how effectively, efficiently, and comfortably users can interact with a website to accomplish their goals.

When evaluating usability, consider questions such as:

Navigation

- Is navigation easy to locate?
- Are navigation labels understandable?
- Can users predict where a link will take them?
- Is navigation consistent across pages?

Content

- Is important information easy to find?
- Are headings meaningful?
- Is the page easy to scan?
- Are paragraphs manageable?

Interaction

- Are buttons recognizable?
- Are links distinguishable?
- Are Calls to Action clear?
- Does the interface provide useful feedback?

Consistency

- Do similar elements behave similarly?
- Does navigation remain consistent?
- Are visual patterns reused?

Efficiency

- How much effort does a user need to complete a common task?
- Are unnecessary steps creating friction?

Usability focuses on the **experience of accomplishing a task**.

4. Accessibility

Web accessibility means designing and developing web content so that people with a wide range of abilities can perceive, understand, navigate, and interact with it.

Accessibility should not be treated as something added to a website at the end.

It is part of good web development.

Some users may:

- use a keyboard instead of a mouse;
- use a screen reader;
- have limited vision;
- have colour-vision differences;
- magnify page content;
- have difficulty with small interactive targets;
- require captions or text alternatives;
- interact with the site using assistive technology.

When performing an introductory accessibility evaluation, consider:

- Is text readable?
- Is there sufficient visual contrast?
- Can links be distinguished?
- Do images appear to communicate information that would require text alternatives?
- Are headings organized meaningfully?
- Can interactive elements be reached using a keyboard?
- Does the interface depend only on colour to communicate meaning?
- Does the page remain understandable when zoomed?

Later in the course, you'll perform more systematic accessibility testing.

For now, the goal is to begin thinking beyond your own experience as a user.

5. Visual Design Supports Communication

Visual design isn't simply decoration.

Design can help users understand:

- what is important;
- what belongs together;
- what is interactive;
- where to look next;
- how information is organized.

Four useful principles for evaluating visual design are:

Contrast → Repetition → Alignment → Proximity

These are often remembered as **CRAP**.

Contrast

Contrast creates visual differences between elements.

Contrast can involve:

- size;
- weight;
- colour;
- shape;
- spacing;
- typography.

Strong contrast can help users distinguish:

```
graph TD; A[PAGE TITLE] --> B[SECTION HEADING]; B --> C[BODY CONTENT]; C --> D[SECONDARY INFORMATION];
```

Ask:

Can the user quickly determine what is most important?

Contrast must also support readability. Text that blends into its background may look subtle but be difficult to read.

Repetition

Repetition creates consistency.

Websites commonly repeat:

- colours;
- fonts;
- button styles;
- navigation patterns;
- spacing;
- card designs;
- heading styles.

Repetition helps users learn the interface.

If every button looks different, users must repeatedly determine what is clickable.

Ask:

Are similar things presented in similar ways?

Alignment

Alignment creates visual relationships between elements.

Poor alignment can make a page feel disorganized even when the user cannot immediately explain why.

Look for relationships among:

- headings;
- paragraphs;
- images;
- cards;
- navigation;
- buttons;
- page margins.

Ask:

Do elements appear intentionally positioned in relation to one another?

Proximity

Proximity helps communicate which elements belong together.

Items that are related should generally appear visually connected.

For example:

```
PRODUCT NAME
Product description
Price
[Buy Now]
```

If the Buy Now button appears much closer to another product, the interface becomes ambiguous.

Ask:

Can users tell which pieces of information belong together?

6. Visual Hierarchy

Visual hierarchy helps users understand the relative importance of information.

A webpage may use:

- size;
- position;
- typography;
- whitespace;
- contrast;

- grouping;

to establish hierarchy.

A clear hierarchy might communicate:

```
graph TD; SITE --> PAGE; PAGE --> SECTION; SECTION --> CONTENT; CONTENT --> ACTION;
```

SITE
↓
PAGE
↓
SECTION
↓
CONTENT
↓
ACTION

Users rarely read every webpage from beginning to end.

They frequently **scan**.

Good hierarchy supports that behaviour.

7. Navigation

Navigation provides a map through the website.

Effective navigation should help users answer questions such as:

- Where am I?
- What sections exist?
- Where can I go?
- How do I return?
- What will happen when I select this link?

When evaluating navigation, examine:

- location;
- visibility;
- wording;
- consistency;
- number of choices;
- organization;
- current-page indication;
- mobile behaviour where applicable.

8. Evidence-Based Evaluation

One of the most important skills in this workshop is learning to separate **preference** from **evaluation**.

Consider:

"I don't like the colours."

This tells us something about the evaluator's preference, but very little about the website.

Compare it with:

"The navigation uses low-contrast text against the background, making the labels difficult to distinguish."

The second statement:

1. identifies a specific feature;
2. identifies a design/accessibility issue;
3. explains the effect on the user.

Use this pattern:

OBSERVATION → PRINCIPLE → USER IMPACT

For example:

The main navigation uses small text with limited contrast against the background (**observation**). This weakens contrast and readability (**principle**), making navigation options more difficult to identify quickly (**user impact**).

A strong evaluation can then add:

RECOMMENDATION

Increase the contrast between the navigation text and background and ensure the text remains clearly readable across viewport sizes.

The complete evaluation becomes:

Observe → Connect → Explain → Recommend

Integrated Tutorial / Guided Activities

Activity A — First Impression

Your instructor will provide or approve a website for this activity.

Do not begin by inspecting the source code.

Open the website as an ordinary user.

Give yourself approximately **30 seconds** to explore the home page.

Record your immediate observations.

Task A1 — Purpose

What do you believe the website is intended to accomplish?

Task A2 — Audience

Who appears to be the intended audience?

What evidence supports your answer?

Task A3 — Primary Action

What does the website appear to want you to do?

Examples might include:

- purchase;
- register;
- learn;
- contact;
- read;
- donate;
- download;
- visit;
- subscribe.

How obvious is that action?

Task A4 — First Impression

Without deciding whether you personally "like" the website, record three things you noticed immediately.

1.

2.

3.

Verification Checkpoint A

- ☐ I identified the site's apparent purpose.
 - ☐ I identified an intended audience.
 - ☐ I identified a likely primary user action.
 - ☐ I recorded observations rather than only personal preferences.
-

Activity B — Evaluate Visual Design

Now evaluate the same page using the four design principles.

Task B1 — Contrast

Identify one example where contrast is used effectively or ineffectively.

Element observed:

What did you notice?

How does this affect the user?

Task B2 — Repetition

Identify a repeated visual pattern.

Examples might include:

- buttons;
- colours;
- cards;
- headings;
- navigation;
- spacing.

Repeated pattern:

Does the repetition improve consistency? Explain.

Task B3 — Alignment

Identify an example of alignment.

Elements observed:

How does the alignment help or interfere with understanding?

Task B4 — Proximity

Find a group of related information.

Information group:

Does spacing clearly communicate that the elements belong together?

Try This — Remove the Design

Imagine that:

- every heading was the same size as the body text;
- every button looked different;
- spacing between all elements was identical;
- nothing aligned with anything else.

How would this affect your ability to understand the page?

Record your response:

Verification Checkpoint B

- ☐ I evaluated contrast.
 - ☐ I evaluated repetition.
 - ☐ I evaluated alignment.
 - ☐ I evaluated proximity.
 - ☐ I connected visual decisions to their effect on the user.
-

Activity C — Evaluate Visual Hierarchy

Look at the webpage without reading every word.

Ask yourself:

Where does my eye go first?

Record the first five things that attract your attention.

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

Now consider:

Is that order intentional?

Does it match what appears to be important?

Can you identify the page's main heading?

Can you identify a primary Call to Action?

Can you quickly distinguish primary content from secondary content?

Verification Checkpoint C

- ☐ I identified the page's visual hierarchy.
- ☐ I identified the primary content.
- ☐ I identified a primary action where applicable.
- ☐ I considered whether the visual hierarchy supports the site's purpose.

Activity D — Navigation Task Test

Now evaluate the website by trying to accomplish actual tasks.

Your instructor will provide tasks appropriate to the selected website.

Example tasks might include:

- Find the organization's contact information.
- Find the price of a product or service.
- Determine the organization's operating hours.
- Find a specific section of information.
- Return to the home page.

For each task, record:

Task	Completed?	Easy / Moderate / Difficult	What helped or interfered?
Task 1			
Task 2			
Task 3			

Now evaluate the navigation.

Are navigation labels understandable?

Is the navigation easy to locate?

Is the navigation consistent?

Do links behave as expected?

Can you tell where you are within the website?

Verification Checkpoint D

- ☐ I completed actual user tasks.
 - ☐ I evaluated navigation based on those tasks.
 - ☐ I documented evidence of what helped or interfered with task completion.
-

Activity E — Introductory Accessibility Check

Accessibility evaluation requires more than visual inspection, but several useful observations can be made immediately.

Task E1 — Keyboard Test

Without using your mouse, press:

Tab

repeatedly.

Observe what happens.

Can you determine which element currently has keyboard focus?

Yes / No / Sometimes

Can you reach interactive elements?

Yes / No / Sometimes

Is the focus indicator visible?

Yes / No / Sometimes

Record one observation:

Task E2 — Zoom Test

Increase browser zoom.

Try:

125% → 150% → 200%

Observe the page.

Does content remain readable?

Does anything overlap?

Does navigation remain usable?

Does horizontal scrolling become necessary?

Task E3 — Images

Locate an image that communicates useful information.

Ask:

If I could not see this image, would I lose important information?

Record your observation.

You will learn later how HTML provides text alternatives for images and how those alternatives can be inspected.

Task E4 — Colour and Contrast

Find text or an interface element where colour is important.

Ask:

- Is the text easy to distinguish from the background?
- Does colour appear to be the only way information is communicated?
- Would the interface still make sense if the colours were difficult to distinguish?

Record your observation:

Verification Checkpoint E

- ☐ I tested keyboard navigation.
- ☐ I observed keyboard focus.
- ☐ I tested browser zoom.
- ☐ I considered image accessibility.
- ☐ I considered colour and contrast.

- ☐ I understand that this is an introductory check, not a complete accessibility audit.
-

Activity F — Inspect with Developer Tools

Workshop 0 introduced browser Developer Tools.

Now you'll use them as part of an evaluation.

Open DevTools and use the element inspector.

Task F1 — Locate the Main Heading

Select the page's primary heading.

What HTML element appears to be used?

Task F2 — Inspect Navigation

Select one of the navigation links.

What element represents the link?

Task F3 — Inspect an Image

Select an image.

Look at the HTML shown in DevTools.

Can you identify an `alt` attribute?

Yes / No

If one exists, record its value:

Based only on this introductory inspection, does the text appear to communicate the purpose of the image?

Task F4 — Change Something Temporarily

Using DevTools, temporarily modify:

- some text;
- a font size; or
- another simple visible property demonstrated by your instructor.

Do not attempt to modify the actual website.

Refresh the page.

What happens?

Why?

Verification Checkpoint F

- ☐ I used DevTools to inspect webpage elements.
 - ☐ I located a heading.
 - ☐ I inspected navigation.
 - ☐ I inspected an image.
 - ☐ I understand that DevTools can support website investigation and troubleshooting.
-

Activity G — Capture Evidence

A good evaluation should provide evidence.

Capture **three screenshots** from the website.

Each screenshot must illustrate a specific observation.

For each screenshot, record:

Screenshot 1

Principle / Issue: _____

Observation:

User Impact:

Screenshot 2

Principle / Issue: _____

Observation:

User Impact:

Screenshot 3

Principle / Issue: _____

Observation:

User Impact:

The screenshot isn't the evaluation.

The screenshot is **evidence supporting your evaluation**.

Activity H — Turn Observations into Recommendations

Select three issues you identified.

For each one, use the complete evaluation pattern:

OBSERVATION → PRINCIPLE → USER IMPACT → RECOMMENDATION

Finding 1

Observation:

Principle:

User Impact:

Recommendation:

Finding 2

Observation:

Principle:

User Impact:

Recommendation:

Finding 3

Observation:

Principle:

User Impact:

Recommendation:

Verification Checkpoint H

- ☐ Each finding identifies something specific.
- ☐ Each finding connects to a design, usability, or accessibility principle.
- ☐ Each finding explains the effect on the user.
- ☐ Each recommendation addresses the identified problem.

Activity I — Compare Two Websites

Your instructor will provide or approve a second website serving a similar purpose.

For example, compare:

- two restaurants;
- two colleges;
- two retailers;
- two tourism websites;
- two government services;
- two technology companies.

The purpose isn't to decide which website you personally prefer.

Compare how the two sites solve similar user problems.

Evaluation Area	Website A	Website B
Purpose is immediately clear		
Primary navigation		
Visual hierarchy		
Contrast		
Repetition/consistency		
Alignment		
Proximity/grouping		
Readability		
Keyboard navigation		
Zoom behaviour		
Primary Call to Action		

Evaluation Area	Website A	Website B
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Overall task clarity

Now identify **two meaningful differences**.

Difference 1

Effect on the user:

Difference 2

Effect on the user:

Reflection

Answer the following questions in your own words.

1. Preference vs. Evaluation

What is the difference between saying:

"I don't like this website"

and performing an evidence-based website evaluation?

2. Usability

What usability issue had the greatest effect on your experience with one of the websites?

Why?

3. Accessibility

Identify one accessibility consideration that you hadn't previously thought about.

4. Design

Which of the four principles — contrast, repetition, alignment, or proximity — was easiest for you to identify?

Explain your example.

5. Users

Did evaluating the website from another user's perspective change anything about your initial opinion?

Explain.

6. Your Semester Website

Identify **three things you want to remember** when you begin planning your own website.

1.

2.

3.

Deliverables

Submit a **Website Evaluation** containing the following:

Part 1 — Website Context

- website names and URLs;
- apparent purpose;
- intended audience;
- likely primary user tasks.

Part 2 — Design Evaluation

Evidence addressing:

- contrast;
- repetition;
- alignment;
- proximity;
- visual hierarchy.

Part 3 — Usability Evaluation

Evidence addressing:

- navigation;
- readability;
- task completion;
- consistency;
- primary actions.

Part 4 — Introductory Accessibility Evaluation

Evidence from:

- keyboard navigation;

- visible focus;
- browser zoom;
- colour/contrast;
- images/text alternatives where observable.

Part 5 — Evidence

Include at least **three annotated or clearly explained screenshots**.

Part 6 — Recommendations

Provide at least **three evidence-based recommendations** using:

Observation → Principle → User Impact → Recommendation

Part 7 — Comparison

Compare the two websites and identify meaningful differences in how they support users.

Part 8 — Reflection

Complete the Workshop 1 reflection questions.

Submission

Submit the completed **Workshop 1 — Website Evaluation** according to the instructions provided in Brightspace.

Where instructed, your submission may include:

- a PDF or document containing your evaluation;
- screenshots supporting your observations;
- links to the websites evaluated.

Before submitting, verify that:

- your name is included;
- website URLs are identified;
- screenshots are readable;
- observations are explained rather than simply listed;
- recommendations connect to evidence;
- reflection questions are complete.

Evaluation Criteria

Workshop 1 — Website Evaluation: 3%

Criteria	Evidence Expected
Website Purpose & User Context	Identifies purpose, audience and likely user tasks using evidence from the websites.
Design Principles	Correctly applies contrast, repetition, alignment and proximity to specific examples.
Usability Evaluation	Evaluates navigation, hierarchy, readability, consistency and task completion from a user perspective.
Accessibility Evaluation	Performs and documents introductory keyboard, focus, zoom, contrast and image/accessibility observations.
Evidence	Uses relevant screenshots and specific observations to support findings.
Recommendations	Provides practical recommendations clearly connected to identified problems and user impact.
Comparison	Identifies meaningful differences between the two websites without relying only on personal preference.
Reflection & Communication	Communicates findings clearly and demonstrates thoughtful reflection on future website-development decisions.

The emphasis is on **reasoning and evidence**, not on finding the largest possible number of problems.

Resources

Use course resources and instructor demonstrations provided through WEBD 1000.

Relevant resources include:

- WEBD 1000 Brightspace materials;
- WEBD 1000 Microsoft Teams channel;
- browser Developer Tools;
- accessibility resources introduced by your instructor;
- course materials covering usability and accessibility;
- course materials covering contrast, repetition, alignment, and proximity.

When evaluating a website, remember that automated tools and browser inspection can provide evidence, but they do not replace thoughtful evaluation by a person.

Academic Integrity

Workshop 1 evaluates **your ability to observe, evaluate, explain, and recommend**.

You may discuss general usability, accessibility, and design concepts with classmates, but your submitted evaluation must represent your own analysis.

Do not:

- copy another student's findings;
- copy online website reviews;
- reuse another person's screenshots and present them as your observations;
- submit AI-generated evaluation statements without independently verifying the claims against the actual website.

If you use an AI tool to help clarify terminology or improve your writing, you remain responsible for inspecting the website yourself and verifying every claim.

A statement that sounds convincing isn't evidence that the statement is correct.

Copyright Notice

Websites examined during this workshop remain the property of their respective owners.

Screenshots should be used only as necessary to support educational analysis within the workshop.

Do not redistribute website content or assets as though they were your own work.

Instructor Note

Workshop 1 is the first direct practical application of **Outcome 1 — Evaluate a variety of web sites for usability and accessibility**.

The workshop intentionally moves students through:

Observe → Test → Inspect → Document → Evaluate → Recommend

The emphasis should remain on developing an evidence-based evaluation mindset rather than producing an exhaustive professional accessibility audit.

Students should begin recognizing that visual design, usability, and accessibility are related but distinct considerations.

Workshop 1 also establishes vocabulary and evaluation habits that should be revisited throughout the semester as students evaluate their own work.

Progressing to the Semester Website Project

You have now completed two important stages:

WORKSHOP 0
Tooling & Workflow Readiness

```
graph TD; A[WORKSHOP 1  
Website Evaluation] --> B[SEMESTER WEBSITE PROJECT  
Website Concept]; B --> C[WEBSITE PLANNING  
Information Architecture]; C --> D[SITEMAP & WIREFRAMES];
```

Before you begin designing your own website, use what you've learned from evaluating other websites.

Your first Semester Website Project decisions should answer:

What is my website for?

Who is it for?

What should users be able to accomplish?

What content will they need?

What design decisions will help rather than interfere with those goals?

That moves us naturally from **evaluating existing websites** to **planning your own**.